and European companies. He felt that it had been difficult to take independent decisions under the previous owner. In contrast, he said: ‘Tata wants us to be autonomous … We can make decisions quickly—What we have seen of Tata is that it is a very principled organisation, with corporate social responsibility high on the agenda, but which works differently from the US or European model.’

This was not Ratan’s first interaction with the Ford officials. He had had discussions with their senior officials in 1999 and a year later to explore possibilities of collaborating on the production of Indica. His three meetings were, however, disappointing as Ford insisted that Tata Motors accept a one-sided agreement.

Almost a decade later, the tables had virtually turned. The year 2008 was the worst annual result in Ford’s 105-year history as it was ‘closing the books on a $14.6 billion loss’ and its revenue had declined by 20 per cent. ‘For [the] struggling Ford’, cash was also needed. Ironically, the Indian automobile giant, which was treated rather dismissively by Ford, had become large enough to help ease the American behemoth’s financial gripes.

It was under these circumstances that on 10 June 2008 Ratan flew to the US to meet William Clay ‘Bill’ Ford Jr, the great-grandson of the founder, and the executive chairman. This came from his desire to meet ‘face-to-face’ the ‘people who sold the company to us’, Ratan said. It was a ‘very affable’ meeting, he added.

But many Indian commentators, described the meeting as one in which Ratan wreaked revenge on having been rebuffed when he had purportedly made the offer to sell the Tata car division to Ford. Neither had Ratan met Bill Ford in 1999 nor had he made any proposal to sell the car division to Ford. There was no such proposal, Ratan asserts.

Ford Motor Company had wanted to work with Tata Motors on the production of the Indica, he added. They wanted a transfer of the production technology. ‘Once the technology was transferred to them, we would have had to source all our material from them,’ Ratan says. He had also written to Jonckheere after their meeting stating that Telco had discussed with Daimler Chrysler the prospects of ‘working together on the Indica’. And as chairman of the group, he believed that ‘it would not be correct to proceed further’, in the matter. He wondered: ‘What is in it for us? And that is where it ended,’ confides Ratan.